

READING JOURNAL

What is a reading journal? Why should I keep a reading journal?

A reading journal is a tool of reflection that allows you to observe your own reading behavior. Reading serves different functions and is associated with different expectations. The more precisely you know why you are reading and for what purpose, the better you can understand your own reading. Over time, you also learn to recognize how you read. How much time you need for certain types of texts, at which points in the reading process you fall into which behavioral patterns or you apply certain strategies. Observations about what works well for you, but also about how you deal with difficulties or which avoidance strategies you use, can help you to constructively control your reading behavior.

What can be recorded in a reading journal?

In your reading journal you can write everything you observe about your reading behavior, but also things that come to your mind while reading.

To reflect on your own reading behavior, the following points/questions, among others, are useful:

Reflecting reading goals

What do I already know?
What do I want to know?
What do I have to understand?
What should I understand? What do the instructors expect of me?
Who/ Which authors are relevant for the topic/ my field of work?

Reflecting time management

How much time do I have to read before the text will be discussed in the seminar?
How much reading time do I schedule?

Reflecting ways of reading

What do I read? (handbooks, journals (which?), anthologies, ...)
Which media do I use to read? (on paper, computer, eReader, tablet, cell phone, ...)
Where do I read? (at my desk, on the sofa, on the train/bus, in the library, ...)
How long do I read? (longer time (how long?), in small sections, every now and then in between, ...)
What else do I do while reading? (nothing, listening to music, ...)
What promotes my concentration? What distracts me?

Reflecting reading behavior

How do I read? (fast - slow; scanning - diagonally, word-for-word; with pen in my hand, ...)
How do I read texts in my feel-good language compared to texts in a foreign language? What is the same?
Where are the differences?
Does my reading behavior differ depending on during which phase of my work I read a text? (In your perception, try to combine reading behavior and work phase and write down your experiences).
Which activities I perform while reading promote my comprehension process?
Has the reading method I have just applied led to a new insight (which I might not have gained with another method)?
How can I use my reading experience in other contexts?